

AstraNova Technologies Pvt. Ltd. — Comprehensive Employee Handbook

Section 1: Introduction and Welcome

Welcome to AstraNova Technologies Pvt. Ltd. (hereinafter referred to as "AstraNova" or "the Company"). Founded in 2019 in Pune, Maharashtra, AstraNova has established itself as an AI-First Organization specializing in Artificial Intelligence, Machine Learning, Data Analytics, Cloud Computing, and Enterprise Software. Our culture is built upon innovation, continuous learning, diversity, and customer-centricity, all while maintaining a hybrid work environment and a deep focus on security.

This Employee Handbook serves as a definitive guide to the policies, practices, and expectations that govern employment at AstraNova. It is designed to provide clear, actionable information for employees and to serve as a robust data source for our internal HR systems.

Section 2: Equal Employment Opportunity and Diversity Policy

2.1 Purpose / Definition

AstraNova is dedicated to creating a workplace that reflects our core value of Diversity & Inclusion. The purpose of this policy is to guarantee equal employment opportunities for all individuals, ensuring a workplace entirely free from discrimination, harassment, bias, or retaliation. We believe that diverse perspectives drive the innovation necessary for cutting-edge AI developments.

2.2 Scope

This policy applies to all individuals associated with AstraNova. This includes permanent full-time employees, part-time employees, interns, trainees, contract workers, consultants, and remote workers based anywhere globally, as well as all applicants during the recruitment process.

2.3 Eligibility

Every individual associated with AstraNova is covered by this policy from their first day of engagement or application, regardless of tenure, department, role, or seniority level.

2.4 Rules & Guidelines

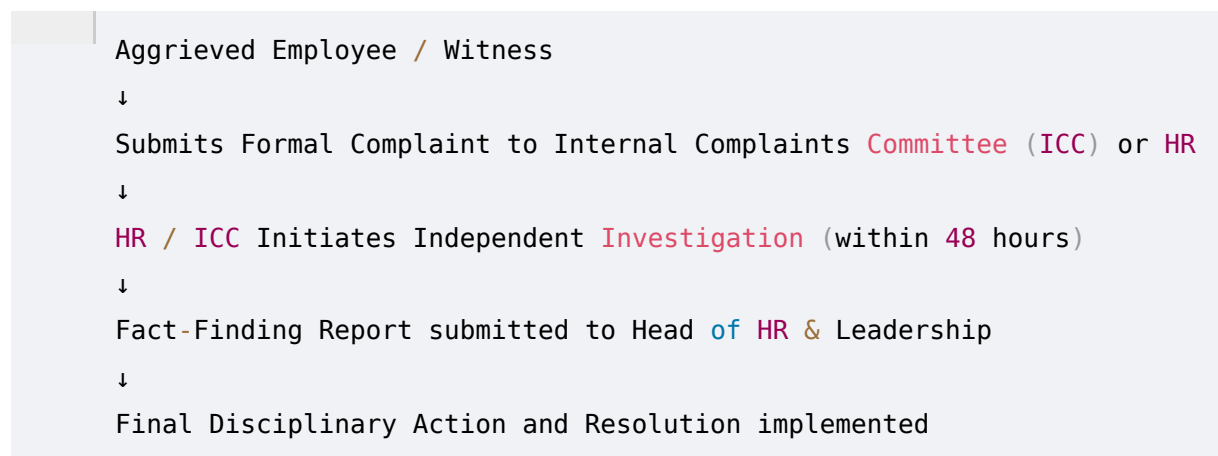
AstraNova prohibits discrimination or harassment based on race, color, religion, caste, creed, sex, gender identity or expression, sexual orientation, national origin, age, disability, marital status, or veteran status. This zero-tolerance policy applies to all aspects of the employment relationship, including:

- Recruitment, hiring, and job placement.
- Performance evaluation, compensation, and promotion systems.
- Access to training, mentorship, and professional development programs.
- Disciplinary actions and employment termination.

All employees must complete mandatory annual Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) training. Harassment of any form—verbal, physical, visual, or digital—will result in immediate disciplinary action up to and including termination of services.

2.5 Process / Workflow

If an employee experiences or witnesses any form of discrimination or harassment, they should follow the reporting framework outlined below:



2.6 Roles & Responsibilities

- **Employee:** Treat all colleagues with dignity and respect. Report any instances of bias or harassment immediately. Complete all assigned DEI training modules.
- **Manager:** Maintain a bias-free team environment. Intervene and report immediately if any discriminatory behavior is observed or reported.
- **HR Department / ICC:** Conduct prompt, impartial, and confidential investigations into all complaints. Ensure support for the complainant and enforce disciplinary actions.
- **Leadership:** Provide resources for DEI initiatives, review high-level reports, and champion an inclusive corporate culture.

2.7 Exceptions

There are no exceptions to the Equal Employment Opportunity and Diversity Policy. AstraNova maintains a strict zero-tolerance stance under all operational, geographic, or emergency circumstances.

2.8 Examples

- *Scenario A:* A hiring manager reviews resumes for a machine learning engineer role and intentionally filters out candidates over a certain age. This constitutes age discrimination and violates AstraNova policy, triggering an HR investigation into the manager's hiring practices.
- *Scenario B:* A remote software engineer experiences persistent, unwelcome comments regarding their cultural background during virtual team meetings. The engineer documents these incidents and reports them to HR, initiating a formal investigation by the Internal Complaints Committee.

2.9 Important Notes

- **Avoid:** Do not wait to report uncomfortable behavior; early intervention prevents an escalation of hostile environments.
- **Best Practice:** Use gender-neutral, respectful language in all corporate Slack channels, emails, and code repositories to foster a supportive and inclusive digital workplace.

Section 3: Attendance, Punctuality, and Work Hours Policy

3.1 Purpose / Definition

As a modern, fast-growing AI software provider, AstraNova balances workplace flexibility with structural consistency. The Attendance, Punctuality, and Work Hours Policy defines corporate expectations regarding core hours, tracking systems, and dependability, ensuring smooth cross-functional collaboration.

3.2 Scope

This policy applies to all permanent full-time employees, part-time employees, and interns working out of the Pune headquarters or operating under the Company's hybrid and remote work arrangements. Contract employees must adhere to the hours specified in their respective vendor agreements.

3.3 Eligibility

All covered individuals must adhere to the attendance tracking guidelines from their official date of joining the Company.

3.4 Rules & Guidelines

AstraNova operates on a flexible 40-hour work week, but establishes core collaboration hours to ensure seamless communication across teams.

- **Core Hours:** All employees must be accessible online or in the office between 11:00 AM and 4:00 PM Indian Standard Time (IST), Monday through Friday.
- **Attendance Tracking:** Employees must log their daily attendance using the internal Human Resources Information System (HRIS) portal or swipe their biometric access cards when working physically at the Pune office.
- **Late Arrivals:** Any arrival or log-in after 11:00 AM IST without prior managerial approval is flagged as a late arrival. Accumulating more than three unexcused late arrivals in a single calendar month will trigger a formal review by the reporting manager.
- **Absence Notification:** If an employee cannot report to work due to sudden illness or an emergency, they must notify their reporting manager via email or Slack by 10:00 AM IST on that day.

3.5 Process / Workflow

The standard process for recording and verifying attendance issues follows this structure:

```
Employee logs hours daily via HRIS portal or biometric check-in
↓
HRIS automatically generates weekly attendance reports for Managers
↓
Manager reviews anomalies (e.g., missed punches or late arrivals)
↓
Manager addresses regular discrepancies directly with Employee
↓
Unresolved attendance issues escalated to HR for formal warning
```

3.6 Roles & Responsibilities

- **Employee:** Log working hours accurately. Maintain availability during core hours and notify managers promptly regarding any unplanned absences.
- **Manager:** Monitor team attendance logs weekly. Approve reasonable requests for flexible hour adjustments and address persistent punctuality issues.

- **HR Department:** Audits monthly compliance reports generated by the HRIS, manages biometric system updates, and administers corrective action plans when necessary.

3.7 Exceptions

- **Client Deployments:** Employees deployed at client sites may follow the operational hours of the client organization, subject to written approval from their delivery head.
- **Medical Emergencies:** Immediate notification requirements are waived if the employee is physically incapacitated, provided a family member notifies HR within 24 hours.

3.8 Examples

- *Scenario A:* A data scientist forgets to log their attendance via the HRIS portal while working from home. To resolve this, they must raise an attendance regularization request within the HRIS portal by the end of the weekly tracking cycle, which their manager then reviews and approves.
- *Scenario B:* An engineer regularly logs in at 12:30 PM IST without a pre-approved flexible hours agreement, causing them to miss critical team stand-ups. The manager schedules a 1-on-1 performance meeting to correct this behavior before it requires HR escalation.

3.9 Important Notes

- **Avoid:** Do not attempt to log attendance or swipe access cards on behalf of another colleague; this is considered fraudulent behavior and leads to immediate disciplinary action.
- **Best Practice:** Set up automatic status updates on corporate messaging channels (e.g., Slack) to indicate when you are stepping away during core collaboration hours.

Section 4: Hybrid and Remote Work Policy

4.1 Purpose / Definition

To support a modern work-life balance and leverage top technical talent, AstraNova operates as a Hybrid Work Environment. The Hybrid and Remote Work Policy sets the framework for splitting time between the physical corporate office and home environments, while maintaining high performance and data security.

4.2 Scope

This policy applies to all permanent employees and long-term interns whose job descriptions allow their functions to be performed via computing infrastructure outside a formal office setting.

4.3 Eligibility

Employees become eligible for the hybrid work model immediately upon hiring, provided their role does not require physical hardware maintenance or specialized on-site data infrastructure access. Full-time, 100% remote arrangements require explicit approval from the Department Head and the HR Director.

4.4 Rules & Guidelines

- **Hybrid Structure:** The standard hybrid framework requires employees to work from the Pune headquarters for a minimum of two days per week, with the remaining three days optional for remote work. Individual teams determine their specific mandatory in-office days.
- **Workspace Security:** Employees working remotely must ensure a private, secure workspace free from distractions. They must access all corporate networks exclusively through the official AstraNova Virtual Private Network (VPN) and utilize Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA).
- **Equipment Provision:** The Company provides a standard-issue laptop, mouse, and keyboard. Employees are responsible for securing a stable, high-speed internet connection (minimum 50 Mbps download speed).
- **Core Availability:** Remote work does not alter the requirement to remain online and available during core hours (11:00 AM – 4:00 PM IST). Camera use is mandatory during all client interactions and internal sprint reviews.

4.5 Process / Workflow

To formalize or modify a hybrid or fully remote schedule, the following workflow must be completed:

```
Employee discusses proposed hybrid schedule with Reporting Manager
↓
Employee submits formal Remote Work Agreement form via HRIS
↓
Reporting Manager reviews operational feasibility and team coverage
↓
Department Head and HR Director provide final systemic validation
↓
IT Provisioning team configures secure VPN and remote access rights
```

4.6 Roles & Responsibilities

- **Employee:** Maintain identical productivity metrics as on-site work. Follow all IT security protocols and attend mandatory in-office team days.
- **Manager:** Assess team output based on delivered metrics rather than physical presence. Coordinate in-office schedules to maximize collaborative windows.
- **IT Infrastructure Team:** Maintain remote access systems, verify security compliance of remote endpoints, and provide hardware support.
- **HR Department:** Track corporate adherence to hybrid guidelines and update agreements annually.

4.7 Exceptions

- **Security Incidents:** If an employee violates IT security protocols while working remotely, their remote work privileges are instantly suspended pending a formal review.
- **Performance Management:** Employees placed on a Performance Improvement Plan (PIP) may be required to work from the Pune office full-time to receive closer mentorship and guidance.

4.8 Examples

- *Scenario A:* A cloud architect wishes to work from their hometown for one month due to personal reasons. They must submit a temporary out-of-station remote work request via the HRIS at least two weeks in advance, securing alignment from their manager regarding time zones and deliverable tracking.
- *Scenario B:* A software tester frequently drops offline during core hours due to local power outages and lacks a backup power solution. The manager will mandate that the employee work from the Pune office until a reliable power backup is installed at their remote workspace.

4.9 Important Notes

- **Avoid:** Do not connect to AstraNova systems via public, unsecured Wi-Fi networks (e.g., at coffee shops or airports) without active VPN tunneling.
- **Best Practice:** Leverage the Company's internet reimbursement program to secure a reliable primary connection and an alternative mobile hotspot backup.

Section 5: Leave and Time-Off Policy

5.1 Purpose / Definition

AstraNova recognizes the vital importance of rest, personal health, and work-life balance. The Leave and Time-Off Policy provides a comprehensive system for employees to take time away from work for relaxation, illness, parental duties, or personal obligations, ensuring structured business continuity.

5.2 Scope

This policy applies to all permanent, full-time employees of AstraNova Technologies Pvt. Ltd. based in India. Interns and contract staff receive modified leave structures outlined in their specific agreements.

5.3 Eligibility

Leave entitlements are calculated based on the calendar year (January 1 to December 31). New hires receive a pro-rated allocation of leaves based on their exact date of joining.

5.4 Rules & Guidelines

AstraNova provides various categories of leave to meet diverse employee needs:

- **Privilege Leave (PL):** Employees accrue 18 days of Privilege Leave per year, credited monthly. PL can be used for planned vacations. A maximum of 30 unused PL days can be carried forward to the next calendar year; any excess beyond 30 days lapses automatically.
- **Casual Leave (CL):** Employees receive 12 days of Casual Leave per calendar year, credited at the start of the year. CL is meant for short, unplanned personal matters and cannot be combined with PL. Unused CL balances lapse entirely on December 31 and cannot be carried forward or encashed.
- **Sick Leave (SL):** Employees receive 12 days of Sick Leave per year to cover illnesses and medical recoveries. Medical certificates are mandatory for any consecutive SL extending beyond two working days. Unused SL lapses at the end of the calendar year.
- **Maternity Leave:** Eligible female employees receive 26 weeks of fully paid Maternity Leave in accordance with the Maternity Benefit Act.
- **Paternity Leave:** Eligible male employees receive 2 weeks of fully paid Paternity Leave, which must be utilized within six months of the child's birth.

5.5 Process / Workflow

The application and approval process for planned time-off is executed as follows:

Employee submits leave request via **HRIS** (minimum 2 weeks prior for **PL**)

↓

HRIS verifies leave balance availability automatically

↓

Reporting Manager reviews team calendar and operational capacity

↓

Manager issues digital approval or rejection via **HRIS**

↓

Leave balance updates automatically, and out-of-office status is logged

5.6 Roles & Responsibilities

- **Employee:** Plan vacations well in advance. Hand over active projects to a designated teammate before taking leave and submit all documentation on time.
- **Manager:** Fairly evaluate leave requests, ensure adequate operational coverage, and prevent team burnout by encouraging leave utilization.
- **HR Department:** Track compliance with statutory leave requirements, audit balances, and process leave encashments during final settlements.

5.7 Exceptions

- **Bereavement Leave:** In the unfortunate event of the death of an immediate family member (spouse, child, parent, sibling), the Company grants up to 5 days of compassionate leave, which does not deduct from standard leave balances.
- **Unpaid Leave:** If an employee experiences extraordinary circumstances and has exhausted all leave balances, they may request Loss of Pay (LOP) leave, which requires the combined approval of the Department Head and HR Director.

5.8 Examples

- **Scenario A:** An employee wants to take a two-week vacation in October. They discuss this with their team during a sprint planning session, ensure their tasks are assigned to a backup colleague, and submit a 10-day Privilege Leave request through the HRIS three weeks in advance.
- **Scenario B:** An employee wakes up with a severe fever. They send a Slack message to their manager by 9:00 AM IST and log a Sick Leave request in

the HRIS portal upon their return to work, attaching a medical certificate if the absence lasted three days.

5.9 Important Notes

- **Avoid:** Do not book non-refundable travel arrangements before receiving formal manager approval for your leave request in the HRIS system.
- **Best Practice:** Always set up an accurate Out-of-Office (OOO) email auto-responder and update your Slack status to indicate your return date and point of contact for emergencies.

Section 6: IT, Data, and AI Security Policy

6.1 Purpose / Definition

As an advanced technology enterprise handling sensitive datasets and machine learning algorithms, information security is critical. The IT, Data, and AI Security Policy establishes comprehensive protocols to safeguard corporate networks, intellectual property, proprietary source code, and customer data from unauthorized access or leakage.

6.2 Scope

This policy applies to all permanent employees, interns, contractors, vendors, and third-party partners who access AstraNova computing resources, networks, repositories, or digital assets.

6.3 Eligibility

Adherence to this policy is mandatory for all covered individuals immediately upon the issuance of their corporate credentials or hardware.

6.4 Rules & Guidelines

- **Data Classification:** All information within AstraNova is classified into four tiers: Public, Internal, Confidential, and Restricted. Customer datasets and proprietary model weights are classified as Restricted and require explicitly logged access permissions.
- **Access Control:** Employees must utilize strong passwords (minimum 14 characters with mixed cases and symbols) updated every 90 days. Sharing passwords or multi-factor authentication codes is strictly prohibited.
- **Device Management:** Only Company-issued laptops with active Mobile Device Management (MDM) profiles may connect to internal systems. Modifying security configurations or disabling antivirus software is a severe compliance violation.

- **AI Model Usage:** Employees must not paste proprietary code, confidential client metrics, or personal data into public, external AI tools or LLM models unless using internal, secured AstraNova enterprise AI instances.
- **Software Installation:** Installation of unauthorized third-party software, browser extensions, or unverified open-source libraries on corporate laptops is forbidden without approval from the InfoSec team.

6.5 Process / Workflow

The reporting and remediation flow for a suspected security breach follows this structure:

```
User discovers or suspects a vulnerability, phishing, or data leak
↓
User immediately emails security@astranova.com or alerts the IT
Hotline
↓
InfoSec Incident Response Team isolates affected hardware or accounts
↓
Investigation conducted to evaluate scope and root cause
↓
Remediation applied, and formal report filed with Leadership and HR
```

6.6 Roles & Responsibilities

- **Employee:** Follow all security protocols, verify recipient identities before sending data, and report suspicious activities instantly.
- **Manager:** Ensure team members complete mandatory security training and audit system access privileges regularly during offboarding or role transitions.
- **InfoSec Team:** Monitor network logs, conduct periodic vulnerability assessments, maintain patch cycles, and lead incident response actions.
- **Leadership:** Set the corporate risk tolerance framework and ensure compliance with global data privacy frameworks (e.g., GDPR, DPDP Act).

6.7 Exceptions

- **Security Research:** Members of the dedicated internal security research or red-team units may be granted exceptions to test system vulnerabilities, provided they operate under explicit, time-bounded written authorization from the Chief Information Security Officer (CISO).

6.8 Examples

- *Scenario A:* An engineer receives an email that looks like an urgent request from the CEO asking for immediate access to an enterprise server repository. Recognizing it as a phishing attempt, the engineer avoids clicking any links and clicks the "Report Phishing" button in their email client.
- *Scenario B:* A data analyst needs to clean a customer dataset using an external open-source utility. Instead of pasting the real dataset online, they use synthetic data for testing or obtain clearance from the InfoSec team to run an approved containerized tool locally.

6.9 Important Notes

- **Avoid:** Never leave your laptop unlocked when away from your workspace, whether at the office or in a hybrid setting.
- **Best Practice:** Always verify open-source software licenses before integrating external packages into AstraNova's commercial product codebases.

Section 7: Code of Conduct and Professional Ethics Policy

7.1 Purpose / Definition

The Code of Conduct and Professional Ethics Policy defines the fundamental principles, values, and ethical standards that guide interactions at AstraNova. It establishes clear expectations for transparency, integrity, professional decorum, and conflict resolution across all aspects of operations.

7.2 Scope

This policy applies universally to all employees, executives, board members, interns, and external consultants representing AstraNova in any capacity.

7.3 Eligibility

Compliance with the Code of Conduct is a core condition of employment, starting from the signing of the employment offer letter throughout the individual's entire association with the Company.

7.4 Rules & Guidelines

- **Professionalism:** Employees must engage with colleagues, clients, and partners respectfully. Bullying, vulgarity, intimidation, and offensive behavior are prohibited in both physical settings and digital channels.
- **Conflict of Interest:** Employees must avoid any financial, business, or personal arrangements that compete with AstraNova's business or interfere

with their job responsibilities. Side-employment or "moonlighting" in tech or AI sectors is strictly prohibited.

- **Gifts and Hospitality:** Employees may not accept or offer gifts, entertainment, or favors exceeding a value of INR 2,000 from clients, suppliers, or competitors without explicit written authorization from HR.
- **Media Interaction:** Only authorized company spokespeople may issue statements to the press, publish details on public blogs, or speak publicly regarding AstraNova's proprietary technologies or financial metrics.

7.5 Process / Workflow

When an ethical violation or conflict of interest arises, the standard resolution pathway proceeds as follows:

```
Whistleblower reports violation via HR portal or anonymous ethics drop-box
↓
Ethics Committee evaluates the validity and assigns an inquiry officer
↓
Comprehensive fact gathering conducted with complete confidentiality
↓
Inquiry findings presented to the Ethics Committee and Head of HR
↓
Corrective action (warning, suspension, or termination) executed
```

7.6 Roles & Responsibilities

- **Employee:** Act with integrity, declare potential conflicts of interest immediately, and safeguard the Company's reputation.
- **Manager:** Lead by example, foster a culture of transparent compliance, and escalate reported ethical lapses without delay.
- **Ethics Committee / HR:** Ensure a safe environment for whistleblowers, investigate complaints thoroughly, and apply disciplinary measures uniformly.

7.7 Exceptions

There are no exceptions to the core ethical standards detailed in this policy. Any deviations regarding gift values or external non-profit board positions require pre-approval from the Board of Directors.

7.8 Examples

- *Scenario A:* A software engineer is offered a weekend freelancing gig to build a data pipeline for an external startup. Since this violates the moonlighting clause and introduces a potential conflict of interest, the engineer declines the opportunity.
- *Scenario B:* An employee notices a colleague copying corporate source code onto an external flash drive. The employee files a confidential report via the ethics portal, allowing the security team to secure the intellectual property before any leak occurs.

7.9 Important Notes

- **Avoid:** Do not use corporate communication tools to broadcast personal political, religious, or non-work-related philosophical beliefs.
- **Best Practice:** Proactively file a conflict disclosure form with HR if a close relative applies for a position within your direct reporting line or with a key vendor.

Section 8: Frequently Asked Questions (FAQ)

Q1: What are the core collaboration hours at AstraNova?

A1: Our core collaboration hours are between 11:00 AM and 4:00 PM Indian Standard Time (IST), Monday through Friday. All hybrid and remote employees must remain fully accessible during this window.

Q2: How many casual leaves am I entitled to each year?

A2: Full-time employees receive 12 days of Casual Leave (CL) per calendar year, which are credited at the start of the year. This allocation is pro-rated for those joining mid-year.

Q3: Can I carry forward my unused Casual Leaves to the next year?

A3: No. Unused Casual Leaves lapse completely on December 31 each year. They cannot be carried forward or converted to cash.

Q4: What is the maximum number of Privilege Leaves I can accumulate?

A4: You can carry forward a maximum of 30 days of Privilege Leave (PL) into a new calendar year. Any accumulated balance exceeding 30 days will lapse automatically on December 31.

Q5: Am I required to submit a medical certificate for taking Sick Leave?

A5: A formal medical certificate issued by a registered medical practitioner is required only if your Sick Leave extends beyond two consecutive working days.

Q6: What should I do if I forget to swipe my biometric card at the office?

A6: You must log in to the HRIS portal and submit an attendance regularization request by the end of the current weekly tracking cycle to avoid being marked as absent.

Q7: How many days per week must hybrid employees work from the Pune office?

A7: Under our standard hybrid model, employees are required to work from the Pune headquarters for a minimum of two days per week, as coordinated by their specific team leads.

Q8: Can I use my personal laptop to work remotely if I connect via the VPN?

A8: No. For data security reasons, accessing internal corporate repositories, customer data, or systems using personal devices is strictly prohibited. You must use your Company-issued laptop.

Q9: Is moonlighting or taking on external freelance tech projects allowed?

A9: No. AstraNova policy strictly prohibits any form of side-employment or freelancing within the technology, AI, or software sectors to prevent conflicts of interest and protect corporate intellectual property.

Q10: Can I use public generative AI tools to debug my project code?

A10: You must not paste proprietary AstraNova source code or client data into external, public AI platforms. You should use internal, secured enterprise AI instances provided by the Company.

Q11: Who should I contact if I suspect my corporate laptop has been compromised?

A11: You must immediately report the issue to our Information Security team by emailing security@astranova.com or calling the internal IT security emergency hotline.

Q12: What is the monetary limit for accepting gifts from corporate vendors?

A12: Employees cannot accept gifts or hospitality exceeding an estimated value of INR 2,000 without prior written approval from the HR Department.

Q13: Does AstraNova offer Paternity Leave?

A13: Yes. Eligible male employees receive 2 weeks of fully paid Paternity Leave, which must be utilized within six months of the child's birth.

Q14: What happens if an employee accumulates more than three unexcused late arrivals in a month?

A14: The internal HRIS automatically flags the trend, and the reporting manager will schedule a formal 1-on-1 performance meeting to discuss and address the attendance issue.

Q15: Can I work remotely from a different city in India for a short period?

A15: Yes, temporary remote work from another city is permissible for valid personal reasons, provided you submit a request through the HRIS and obtain written approval from your manager at least two weeks in advance.